

Below the Kiln

by Douglxss Burley Johnson

The scream hit us while we were still on the wrong side of the chain-link.

We were three kids on a cut fence north of Route 248, Nazareth side, where the old kiln galleries run under the unused plant buildings and the quarry lip drops into limestone that has been chewed for a hundred years. My name is Eli Markowicz, and I was seventeen that October night when Nate carried the lantern. Mara had the bolt cutters we were not supposed to have. I had my father's work gloves and a cheap phone with no signal once the rock closed over us. We had come for a dare and a shortcut back toward town. We stayed for a voice that did not belong to any of us.

The scream came again, longer, from under a steel grate set in concrete beside a brick kiln shell that had not fired since before we were born. Heat from the day's sun still lived in that brick the way heat lives in a stone wall after a long afternoon. Dust sat white on every ledge. A posted board by the grate, plastic-covered and yellowed, said FLOODGATE TEST / LOWER GALLERY / 2300 HRS / STAY CLEAR. Nate held the lantern high. The glass threw a yellow

circle on the grate bars and on a moth that had died there with its wings open, stuck in a crack of rust.

"Somebody's down there," Mara said.

"Somebody wants us down there," Nate said. "That's different."

I put my gloves on the latch and found it already sprung. The grate lifted on hinges that screamed their own smaller scream. Below it a steel ladder dropped into dark that smelled like wet limestone and old oil. The scream under us broke into words we could not parse, then into a scrape of a large body moving on rock. My stomach went tight. Mara swung her legs onto the ladder first. Nate cursed and followed because he would not leave her. I came last and pulled the grate shut over our heads so a night watch would not spot an open hole from the road.

The ladder ended on a concrete floor that pitched toward a black mouth of tunnel. Kiln brick lined the first twenty feet, glazed black where flame had once licked it. Deeper in, the walls went to bare limestone cut with drill scars. Water ran somewhere ahead in a thin sheet, and the sound of it made the whole place feel like a throat. Nate's lantern swung and threw our shadows long. Mara's bolt cutters clicked against a pipe. My phone flashlight made a weak white cone that died at thirty feet.

We ran toward the scrape.

Loose grit went under our sneakers and made every step a small slide. Nate's lantern handle burned hot against his palm from the bulb, and he switched hands without slowing. Mara's bolt cutters caught a hanging cable and threw a bright spark that died on wet stone. My father's gloves smelled like gasoline from the lawn mower he had cleaned that afternoon, a smell that had no job in a kiln gallery and stayed with me anyway.

The tunnel bent twice. On the second bend a figure filled the passage from floor almost to ceiling, shoulders wrong for a man, head ducked under pipes we would have cleared without thinking. He wore a torn coat that might have been canvas once, and his bare feet left wet prints the size of dinner plates. One calf was cut open and bleeding dark onto the limestone. In his left hand he held a length of rebar like a walking staff. When the lantern hit his face, his eyes were too far apart and too steady, and his mouth opened on teeth that did not match any dentist chart in Northampton County.

Nate stopped so hard I ran into his back.

The tall one spoke first. His English came out thick, as if he had learned it from men who shouted over machines.

"Daylight," he said. "Before the gates. The water takes the low rooms. I have been under too long."

Mara did not raise the bolt cutters. She raised her free hand the way you raise a hand to a dog you have not met.

"Who hurt you," she asked.

"Stone," he said. "And time. And the ones who sealed the hatch when the pumps still lied about the aquifer." He tipped the rebar toward a side gallery where water already stood ankle-deep. "Your board says twenty-three hundred. The siren will tell the truth if the board lies."

My phone screen read 10:41, which left nineteen minutes if the board was honest.

"You're not human," Nate said. His voice stayed flat, the way it stayed flat when a teacher asked him a question he had already decided not to answer.

The tall one laughed once, short. "Remnant. The old blood that did not drown. Some of us ran into the mountains. Some of us went into the rock and waited for a sky that would take us

without a spear. Your fathers quarried our waiting room and called it industry." He shifted his weight and hissed when the cut calf took the load. "I am climbing. You may climb with me or drown with the rats. Choose."

Behind us, farther up the ladder shaft, a metal clang rolled down. A watchman's flashlight, maybe, or wind on the grate. Ahead, the thin sheet of water thickened and took a second channel along the wall, cold against my ankle when I stepped wrong. The countdown was already in the rock.

Nate's jaw worked. Mara wiped her nose with her sleeve and left a white streak of dust. I tasted blood where I had bitten the inside of my cheek without meaning to.

We followed him because the ladder behind us was a single throat and the water ahead was a clock.

He moved faster than his wound should have allowed. We scrambled to keep up. The lantern bumped Nate's thigh and threw light across painted arrows on the wall, faded orange, pointing toward GALLERY C and PUMP ROOM and FLOODGATE KEY / PANEL 4. Mara read the last one out loud. The tall one made a sound that might have been approval.

"Your plant men leave tools for the living," he said. "Use them."

Panel 4 was a red metal box bolted to a pillar where three tunnels met. A plastic tag hung from a brass key on a ring: FLOODGATE / LOWER / TURN LEFT TO LOCK BEFORE RELEASE. Beside the box a steel wheel the size of a truck tire waited on a stem that went into the floor. A second wheel farther along the gallery controlled the open gate that would dump settling-basin water into the low rooms when the test ran. The tall one pointed at the keyed wheel with the rebar.

"Lock that. Then the shaft. Then daylight."

Nate shook his head. "I'm not turning plant equipment. We call 911 when we get a signal and we leave."

"In nineteen minutes the low rooms fill," the tall one said. "Your signal is a joke under limestone. Your hands are not."

Mara put her palm on the red box until dust stuck to her skin, then looked at me, not at Nate.

"Eli. You worked summers at your uncle's yard. You know a wheel from a prayer."

The wheel I knew. My uncle prayed over invoices the same way he prayed over a jammed hoist, short and plain, as if God were a foreman who preferred clear speech. Watching him do it never made me join in. Tonight the dark pressed on my ears the way deep water presses on a chest, and the press was not only rock. A hate in the lower gallery sat heavy against the Name Mara's church said on Sundays. The hate arrived the way a cold draft arrives under a door.

"Do it," Mara said.

I pulled the key. The brass was cold and gritty. It seated in the panel lock with a scrape. I turned it left until the tumblers gave, then put both gloved hands on the steel wheel and leaned. The stem complained. Rust broke. The wheel came a quarter turn, then half, then a full hard circle that locked a gate somewhere in the dark with a thud that came up through our boots. Water noise changed pitch as the thin sheet in the side gallery slowed.

"Again," the tall one said. "The second stem. The open one. Close it before the siren."

We ran. The second wheel sat lower, already damp, with a film of limestone grit on the rim. Nate swore and put his hands on it with mine because even a man who hates mysteries will pull on a stuck gate when drowning is the other option. Mara stood with her back to the pillar and spoke out loud, not to us.

"Holy Spirit, lead. In Jesus' name, hold what we cannot see. Armor on. Lance out. Amen."

She did not preach. She named the help the way a person names a tool on a bench when the dark is trying to take your breath. The press in the air eased a fraction, the way a headache eases when a window opens. Nate heard her and snorted through his teeth and kept turning. The wheel locked. Another thud. Somewhere a siren wound up on the surface, thin through rock, and then cut off as if a man at a board had aborted a test he no longer trusted.

The tall one did not thank us with soft words. He tipped the rebar toward a vertical shaft with steel rungs set in poured concrete, a maintenance chimney that climbed toward a hatch marked in stencil: SURFACE / QUARRY LIP / AUTHORIZED ONLY.

"Climb," he said. "I am too wide for your manners. I will take the service stair."

He limped into a side stairwell we had missed, shoulders scraping brick. We took the rungs. My gloves slipped once on wet steel and my knee banged a rung hard enough to bring tears. Nate climbed above me with the lantern hanging from his belt loop by a carabiner, glass knocking. Mara came under me and kept saying the Name under her breath the way some people count steps. The hatch at the top was dogged with a wheel dog. I spun it, shoved, and night air hit us cold and clean, smelling of diesel from Route 248 and wet leaves from the scrub along the quarry fence.

We spilled out onto gravel beside a settling basin that reflected the plant lights in broken sheets. My lungs took the cold air in hard gulps. Limestone dust coated my tongue. The siren stayed dead. A single sodium lamp hummed on a pole and threw our shadows long toward the fence. In the scrub to our left the tall one came up from a service door we had never noticed, coat

torn wider, calf still bleeding, rebar still in his fist. He stood to his full height under the open sky and tipped his face up like a man drinking.

For a long breath nobody spoke.

Then he looked at Mara.

"Your lance reached farther than your arms," he said. "The old ones taught men to call on powers that answer. Most of your age call on screens." He shifted the rebar to his other hand. "I am not your angel. I am not your devil. I am what was left when the long water rose and some of us chose stone over sky. Your book knows my fathers. Your town digs my floor."

Nate wiped limestone dust from his mouth with the back of his wrist.

"Cool story," Nate said. "We're done. You're hurt. We get you to a hospital and we forget the rest."

The tall one showed those wrong teeth.

"Your hospital would measure me and fear me and lock me. I will go into the hills toward the mountain your maps still call Blue. If your watchmen come, tell them a pipe burst and three fools fixed a wheel." He set the tip of the rebar into the gravel and left it standing. "Keep the key. Hands that lock a gate against drowning have already chosen a side, even if the mouth lags."

He turned and moved into the scrub with a gait that covered ground too fast for a wounded man. Brush closed behind him. A truck passed on 248 with its high beams up and did not slow. We stood under the sodium lamp with dust on our clothes and the floodgate key still warm in my glove from my fist.

Mara took the key from me, wiped it on her jeans, and hung the plastic tag back through the ring.

"We put it back," she said. "Then we get out before a real watch finds the grate."

We went back down only far enough to reseal the key in Panel 4 and close the red box. The locked wheels stayed locked. Water in the side gallery had gone quiet. On the way up the second time I saw, stuck to a pipe with old electrical tape, a faded sticker of a cartoon hard hat giving a thumbs-up, the kind safety offices hand out in the nineties, and we climbed past it under the lantern.

On the surface Nate walked ahead of us along the fence line toward the cut we had made. He did not look at Mara when he spoke.

"I turned a wheel," he said. "I did not join a church. Don't baptize a floodgate key and call me converted. Whatever that was, it can stay in the quarry. I like daylight and lab reports and not knowing the bloodlines of giants."

"I know," Mara said. "I'm not your Holy Spirit."

The rebar stayed in my hands. It was too long for a clean carry, so I walked with it like a ridiculously tall hiking pole until we reached Nate's car parked on a side street off East Lawn. I slid it into the trunk on a blanket beside a spare and a jug of washer fluid that had gone half empty since August. Nobody talked on the ride toward Nazareth's square. The Moravian steeple sat dark against a clearer sky than the tunnels had promised. My knee throbbed. Mara texted her mother that we were fine and late. Nate turned the radio up on a station that played songs about trucks and heartbreak and left the volume there like a wall.

Weeks later the local paper ran a short note about an aborted floodgate test at the plant and a maintenance hold while valves were inspected. Nobody mentioned a tall man in the scrub. Nobody mentioned three kids. I went back once in daylight with a hard hat from my uncle's truck and a story about a school project on industrial heritage, and a plant man who believed me pointed at the kiln shells from outside the fence and talked about barrels per day and ownership

changes from Nazareth Cement through Coplay and Essroc and the names that came after. He did not offer a tour of Gallery C. I did not ask.

Nate still sits with me at lunch some Fridays at the community college and argues that prayer is a coping noise people make when the dark gets loud. He will grant that the wheels locked and that we did not drown. He will not grant a Person on the other end of Mara's plain sentences. Mara transferred to a state school and sends photos of geology field trips where the rock is honest and above ground. The rebar lived in my closet until my mother asked about the rust stain on the carpet, and then I wiped it down and hung it in the garage beside the snow shovel, where it looks like scrap and is not.

At twenty-one I still cannot map how deep those galleries run under Nazareth, or how many remnants chose stone, or whether the hate that pressed in the low rooms had a name Mara's church would recognize on sight. What stays clear is the brass key on a plastic tag in my gloves while a countdown ran and a wounded tall one waited on a stair. Mara named a Helper the way you name a tool you trust. Nate turned the same wheel and went home unchanged in the one way that matters to him.

If you ever stand by that chain-link north of 248 and hear a scream under a grate beside a dead kiln, look at the board for the hour, and whether you have a friend who will pray without making a speech, and a friend who will pull on steel even while he hates the story. The veil under a cement town is thinner than the maps admit. Daylight is still the right direction. The key still turns left to lock.

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